Re: Reading assignment - Velocity

Name/Email: Shaira Katuwal, skatuwal@iu.edu

Team 9

Date: February 8, 2026

In the previous reflections on “All in” and “Courage”, I found myself struggling to balance the internal mechanics of our team: how we commit to one another and where we find the bravery to start. Peter Kaufman’s essay on Velocity provides a physical framework for those concepts. Meaning, if being all-in is the state of the engine, courage is the spark to start, and velocity is the actual movement that determines whether we remain stuck in one place or figure our way through various challenges in this practicum project.

The kinetic energy formula (KE = 1/2 mv^2) suggests that while mass increases linearly, velocity increases exponentially. This applied to our team, mass is what we are collectively able to contribute, in terms of combined technical or soft skills, and velocity is the speed at which we execute. As my teammate Paphawarin (Rin) noted in her reflection, velocity is the "force" that allows us to use the power we’ve built.

The most important takeaway for me was the difference between speed and velocity as discussed in this reading. In physics, we are taught that velocity is a vector quantity that requires magnitude and direction. As someone who admittedly overthinks before speaking in class, I realize now that my hesitation is often an attempt to perfect the "vector" at the total expense of "magnitude". I, too, have been sitting at the top of the hill like the “Red Truck” in Kaufman’s analogy, full of potential energy but notallowing it to fully translate into kinetic energy. Kaufman argues that the world belongs to the “fast-moving and lightweight”. This resonates with my personal journey of switching careers from a bachelor's in computer science to a master's in finance, moving from my home country to a place thousands of miles away, learning a new language, and surviving a new environment. Over the last eight years, my life has been on so many of the fast-moving phases where I had to make quick decisions and act upon them instantaneously. In retrospect, I worked in a direction at a certain magnitude, and that brought me here to IU Kelley, taking practicum II. The key takeaway is that velocity is what ensures growth and positive changes in one's life.

As my team continues to work on our project, velocity has always played a key role; first in securing a sponsor and then in maintaining the momentum to get things done. Kaufman highlights how Warren Buffett wins deals by being the first to respond with a "yes" or "no" while others are still forming committees. Our team also took the same approach when reaching out to sponsors. We were effective in allocating initial tasks of reaching out to connections, communicating leads, creating business proposals, and showing up at the sponsor meetings prepared. This led us to finding our sponsors, Cole McNeely and Kent Virum, for the Bloomington Baseball Project. By moving efficiently with clear direction and intention, we were able to secure a great project that the whole team is very excited to start on.

Over the next few weeks, the challenge will shift from being a fast mover to maintaining a constant velocity for our team. As we enter this foundational phase, our goal is to maintain consistency across communication channels within the group and with our sponsors, taking a step back to analyze the problem, and creating a blueprint of our next steps before rushing into any substantial tasks. This consistent movement reduces the uncertainty I have previously written about in my other writings.

Overall, I can see how Kaufman’s view on kinetic energy and velocity is relatable to our daily challenges. However, the idea of “intensive velocity” is something that I think does not fully translate to our project. I find myself disagreeing with the notion that speed is almost always a superior replacement for the heavy and slow. In my essay on courage, I noted that owning mistakes is a sign of strength. Sometimes, the highest velocity can lead to hiding mistakes to maintain the appearance of progress. Kaufman quotes Patton saying, "An imperfect plan implemented immediately and violently today is better than a perfect plan tomorrow." In warfare, this might always be correct, but in financial modeling, an imperfect plan implemented violently can lead to major failure. My teammate Paphawarin (Rin) says, and I agree, that speed without the right vector just doubles the mistakes. There is a terminal velocity for any project, a speed beyond which the friction of human error and ethical oversight becomes too great to ignore, and hence, at that point, intensive velocity no longer holds.

For our team, velocity is not just about moving fast; it's about sustaining the momentum in an all-in environment where our values align, and goals are clear. As I reflect on this essay, I will make sure that my team can showcase our potential fully through this project and reach the finish line with a meaningful impact.